

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Engineering English

Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For mechanical, electrical, civil, systems, industrial, test, quality, manufacturing, and field engineers, plus engineering managers and technical project leads.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Requirements and Constraints

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Design Reviews and Technical Pushback

State a concern respectfully and propose a practical route forward.

03 Failure Modes and Reliability

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

04 Testing, Validation, and Data Interpretation

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

05 Manufacturability and Cost Engineering

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

06 Safety Factors and Compliance

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

07 Field Issues and Customer Communication

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

08 Systems Integration and Interface Control

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one case and saying a response. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, conversation, writing, and revision.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Requirements and Constraints

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

A customer asks for a "lightweight and durable" enclosure without specifying weight, operating conditions, or required life.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

requirement - A condition or capability that must be met for a stated purpose.

constraint - A limit that restricts the available choices or amount of work possible.

tolerance - The permitted variation from a specified value or dimension.

tradeoff - A choice that improves one objective while giving up something on another.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Improve this sentence: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when the review starts?
 - B. Could you confirm when does the review start?
 - C. Could you confirm when starts the review?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?
 - B. Who will present the report at the meeting?
 - C. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Design Reviews and Technical Pushback

State a concern respectfully and propose a practical route forward.

SITUATION

A design review is moving toward approval while one interface assumption remains undocumented.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

design review - A structured evaluation of a design at a defined stage.

design rationale - The reasons and evidence supporting a design choice.

risk - Uncertainty that may affect objectives or expose people or assets to harm or loss.

verification - Checking whether specified requirements have been met.

3. Notice the language

Acknowledge the goal without pretending agreement. Name the specific problem and its implication, then ask a focused question or propose a next step. Be direct when a safety or ethical boundary requires it.

I understand the goal. My concern is

That statement goes beyond

Could we ... before confirming ...?

Improve this sentence: That idea is ridiculous.

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Disagree with a useful reason

4. Check the language

1. Which response identifies a specific assumption and evidence against it?
 - A. The proposal appears optimistic, and I would prefer a slower approach.
 - B. I would like another discussion before we proceed with the proposal.
 - C. The proposal assumes the review is complete; the record shows it is still open.
2. Which follow-up makes disagreement actionable?
 - A. Could we ask for general feedback before sending the next update?
 - B. Could we resolve the missing approval before confirming the plan?
 - C. Could we confirm the plan and discuss the missing approval later?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You want to move quickly and initially overlook a relevant condition. Ask why it matters, then consider a practical route forward that respects the real constraint.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Failure Modes and Reliability

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

A component fails during one test. The team has not reproduced the failure or checked the test setup.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

failure mode - A specific way in which a component, process, or system can fail.

FMEA - Failure mode and effects analysis, a structured method for identifying how a process or product can fail and prioritizing controls.

reliability - The ability to perform an intended function consistently under stated conditions over time.

duty cycle - The pattern of operating time and conditions used to describe equipment use.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Improve this sentence: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change definitely caused the delay.
 - B. The change may have contributed to the delay.
 - C. The change must have caused the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. In this pilot, the observed result was ...
 - B. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...
 - C. Across the service, the observed result was ...

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Testing, Validation, and Data Interpretation

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

A prototype passes a test on three samples. A presentation calls the design proven for every operating condition.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

prototype - An early version used to explore or test a design.

acceptance criteria - Specific conditions a deliverable must meet to be accepted.

validation - Confirming that an output or system meets needs for its intended use under defined conditions.

sample size - The number of independent units or observations included in a defined analysis.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Improve this sentence: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
 - B. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
 - C. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?
 - B. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?
 - C. How would you describe the next step in your own words?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Manufacturability and Cost Engineering

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

SITUATION

Two designs use different tooling and assembly steps. One has a lower material cost but higher assembly time.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

DFM - Design for manufacturability: shaping a design so it can be made effectively and consistently.

tooling - Equipment or fixtures used to shape, assemble, or produce a product.

yield - The proportion of production meeting defined requirements; in finance, a return measure with a different calculation.

cycle time - The time needed to complete one defined production or work cycle.

3. Notice the language

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Improve this sentence: This option is more better.

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Explain a fair comparison

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence expresses a clear contrast?
 - A. Option A is faster because option B costs less.
 - B. Option A is faster, so option B costs less.
 - C. Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.
2. A rate increases from 6% to 7%. What is the absolute difference?
 - A. An increase of seven percentage points.
 - B. An increase of one percentage point.
 - C. An increase of one percent relative to the original rate.

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Safety Factors and Compliance

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

SITUATION

A review note says a design is "compliant" without identifying the applicable requirement or review evidence.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

safety factor - A defined design ratio or allowance addressing uncertainty between expected loading and capacity.

code compliance - Conformity with the applicable building, engineering, or other technical code requirements.

margin - The difference or allowance between values; in business, a measure of profitability.

liability - Legal responsibility or an obligation; in accounting, an amount or duty owed.

3. Notice the language

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Improve this sentence: Please revert soonest with the necessary.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask for an actionable next step

4. Check the language

1. What does 'Please send it by Thursday' normally mean?
 - A. Keep sending it regularly until Thursday.
 - B. Send it no later than Thursday.
 - C. Send it on Thursday, but not earlier.
2. Which request gives the recipient enough detail to act?
 - A. Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?
 - B. Could you confirm that the review is important?
 - C. Could you confirm that you received my earlier message?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Field Issues and Customer Communication

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

SITUATION

A customer received a field-failure update that stated an unconfirmed cause as fact. The investigation is still open.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

field failure - A product failure occurring during use outside the development or production setting.

warranty - A promise or contractual assurance about a product or work, with defined terms and remedies.

corrective action - Action taken to fix a current problem and prevent recurrence.

installation condition - A circumstance of how or where equipment was installed that may affect its performance.

3. Notice the language

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Improve this sentence: I'm sorry if you failed to understand.

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Repair a misunderstanding

4. Check the language

1. Which apology takes responsibility for unclear wording?
 - A. I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear.
 - B. I'm sorry the process took longer than expected.
 - C. I'm sorry we could not meet the original date.
2. What should follow an apology for an incorrect date?
 - A. A longer explanation that never states the correct date.
 - B. A new guaranteed date even if it is unverified.
 - C. The corrected date and the current confirmation status.

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Systems Integration and Interface Control

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

SITUATION

A hardware interface changed after software testing began. The integration team needs the version and affected tests.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

interface control - Managing the agreed technical relationships between components or systems.

integration - Connecting components or organizations so they work together as intended.

regression test - A test checking whether a change has broken previously working behavior.

configuration management - Controlling and recording the versions and settings of a system or product.

3. Notice the language

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Improve this sentence: Someone should follow up on this.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Transfer information and responsibility

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence checks that responsibility has been accepted?
 - A. I mentioned the check in my earlier email.
 - B. The check appears somewhere in the notes.
 - C. Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.
2. Which response best checks a critical handoff detail?
 - A. I saw the message, so no clarification is needed.
 - B. So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?
 - C. I assume all results are final, so we can finish.

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response, not a script to memorize. Your written version needs a subject line, an opening, and appropriate context. Assess it using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Requirements and Constraints

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: A - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

B: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

C: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

Check 2: C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

B: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

C: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

Model response: Could you define the target weight, operating conditions, and expected life?
We need measurable requirements to discuss the tradeoffs and evaluate a design consistently.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Design Reviews and Technical Pushback

Editing example: My concern is that the proposal assumes capacity we have not confirmed.

The revised sentence identifies a testable concern about the proposal. It leaves room for a constructive response.

Check 1: C - The proposal assumes the review is complete; the record shows it is still open.

A: This expresses a preference, but does not identify the assumption or the record that contradicts it.

B: This requests discussion without stating the specific assumption or evidence.

C: It connects the concern to a specific assumption and record.

Check 2: B - Could we resolve the missing approval before confirming the plan?

A: General feedback does not directly address the missing approval.

B: It names the unresolved condition and a practical next step.

C: This confirms the plan before resolving the stated approval condition.

Model response: I support moving the review forward, but this interface assumption needs to be explicit. Could we record it and identify the verification needed before treating that part of the design as settled?

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Failure Modes and Reliability

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: B - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

B: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

C: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

Check 2: A - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

B: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

C: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

Model response: The failure occurred in this test, but its mechanism is not established. I'll describe the observed behavior and test conditions separately from the possible explanations.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Testing, Validation, and Data Interpretation

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

B: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

C: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

Check 2: C - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

B: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

C: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

Model response: The three samples met the criteria under the tested conditions. That does not establish performance under every condition. I'll state the sample size and limits of the test clearly.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Manufacturability and Cost Engineering

Editing example: This option is better on cost, but slower to deliver.

'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Check 1: C - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.

A: 'Because' claims a causal connection that is not given.

B: 'So' implies one fact causes the other.

C: 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.

Check 2: B - An increase of one percentage point.

A: The new rate is 7%; the difference between the rates is one percentage point.

B: Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

C: A one-percent relative increase on 6% would be 6.06%, not 7%.

Model response: The material cost favors the first design, while assembly time favors the second. Let's compare the full manufacturing assumptions before calling either design cheaper overall.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Safety Factors and Compliance

Editing example: Could you send the missing document and confirm when it will be available?

The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Check 1: B - Send it no later than Thursday.

A: This interprets a deadline as a continuing activity, which would use "until".

B: 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.

C: "By Thursday" permits earlier delivery; it is not restricted to that day.

Check 2: A - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

A: The requested action and information are explicit.

B: This checks importance rather than identifying the needed document version.

C: This checks receipt, not which version is required for the review.

Model response: Could you identify the requirement, revision, and supporting evidence for that statement? We need a traceable basis for the compliance claim and review by the responsible specialist.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Field Issues and Customer Communication

Editing example: I'm sorry my message did not explain the timing clearly.

The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Check 1: A - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear.

A: This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.

B: This acknowledges duration, but does not take responsibility for the unclear wording.

C: This acknowledges a missed date, not the communication problem in the question.

Check 2: C - The corrected date and the current confirmation status.

A: The reader still lacks the information they need.

B: An unsupported new promise can create a second misunderstanding.

C: A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

Model response: Our earlier update overstated the cause. The investigation is still open, and the confirmed finding is the observed failure described below. I'm sorry for the confusion; we'll clearly label hypotheses in future updates.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Systems Integration and Interface Control

Editing example: Please confirm which team has accepted the follow-up task.

The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Check 1: C - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.

A: Mentioning a task does not show that anyone accepted it.

B: A written record alone does not identify who will act.

C: It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.

Check 2: B - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?

A: Receiving a message is not the same as confirming its meaning.

B: This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

C: It changes pending information into a final result.

Model response: The interface changed in this revision. I've listed the affected signals and tests for review. Please confirm the configuration your team will use and which checks need to be repeated.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Engineering English

Professional audience: mechanical, electrical, civil, systems, industrial, test, quality, manufacturing, and field engineers, plus engineering managers and technical project leads

Scope: These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Lesson 01: Requirements and Constraints

Original fictional case: A customer asks for a "lightweight and durable" enclosure without specifying weight, operating conditions, or required life.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: requirement: A condition or capability that must be met for a stated purpose. / constraint: A limit that restricts the available choices or amount of work possible. / tolerance: The permitted variation from a specified value or dimension. / tradeoff: A choice that improves one objective while giving up something on another.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Could you define the target weight, operating conditions, and expected life? We need measurable requirements to discuss the tradeoffs and evaluate a design consistently.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Get feedback on a draft

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TASK: Coach my workplace writing

1. Ask me to paste my own fictional or anonymized draft and identify its reader and purpose. If the reference gives a writing task, mention that task as the default. If it is a dialogue, suggest a brief follow-up message that records its outcome and open questions. Stop and wait. Do not write the message for me first.
2. Once I supply the draft, check it against the reference. If an ambiguity changes the meaning, ask one focused question before rewriting. Do not assume that the draft is correct evidence for a new deadline, approval, diagnosis, cost or commitment.
3. Give feedback in three parts: one effective phrase with a reason; up to three priority improvements, quoting my words; and one short revision task for me. Prioritize incorrect facts or unclear action before minor grammar. For each language correction, explain why it matters to this reader. Label optional stylistic alternatives separately and preserve my level of certainty and intended politeness.
4. Stop and wait for my revision. Then compare the two attempts, identify an improvement and offer one edited version that preserves my voice and purpose. Keep the requested length; if none is specified, use 70-110 words. Explain any meaningful change rather than silently making the message stronger or more certain.
5. Close with one phrase worth reusing and a short transfer task for a different fictional reader. Wait for my attempt before providing another model.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level